Copilot Credit Governance

A practical guide to where Copilot Credits go, who can stop them, and which controls are real.

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COVERS

Copilot Studio · Cowork · Work IQ API

WHAT WE COVER

Two admin centres, one credit pool, and only some of the controls you would expect.

Every environment has a tap into your credit pool

Open by default. On every environment. Including the ones nobody remembers creating.

TENANT PREPAID CREDIT POOL

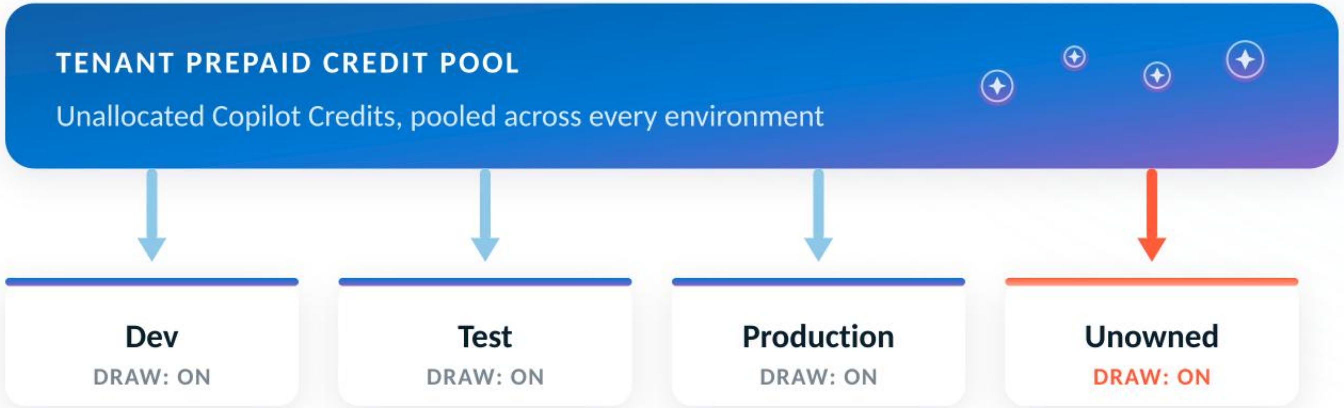
Unallocated Copilot Credits, pooled across every environment

Dev	Test	Production	Unowned
DRAW: ON	DRAW: ON	DRAW: ON	DRAW: ON

Vinod Dhanwe · Snr Solutions Architect · swipe for the two ways to close it

THE DEFAULT

Nobody turned this on. It was already on.



Straight from the documentation

"Draw from the available capacity in my tenant" is selected by default for eligible Copilot Studio environments whenever no allocation configuration exists.

Why it bites harder now

GitHub Copilot harness agents bill for all usage — building, testing, evaluating and running. No Microsoft 365 Copilot licence covers any of it, and developer and trial environments moved to usage-based billing on 1 September 2026 — that change has already landed.

Consumption is attributed at environment and agent level, never to the user who triggered it.

FIX ONE

The supported fix is a checkbox

Power Platform admin centre

Licensing › Products › Copilot Studio › Manage Copilot Credits

Environment	**AGENTS – PROD**
Copilot Credit allocation	**5,000 credits**
Capacity overages	☐ **Draw from the available capacity in my tenant** leave this cleared

Save

Prepaid draw

Capped at the allocation. With no allocation at all, the environment cannot touch tenant capacity.

STOPPED

Pay-as-you-go

Untouched. A linked billing plan keeps metering to the Azure subscription regardless.

STILL OPEN

No Managed Environment required

A plain per-environment setting. Set it, and the tap closes for that environment alone.

An allocation alone is not a boundary. It still leaks if the environment can keep drawing behind it.

FIX TWO

Managed Environments turns it from a setting into a policy

1. **Turn on Managed Environments**
   On the environments that host your agents. An entitlement, not a purchase.

2. **Put them in an environment group**
   Group the agent environments so one policy covers all of them.

3. **Publish the cost-control rule**
   Cost controls — Draw from tenant credit pool. Set it off and publish.

What the rule takes away

- It governs every environment in the group — including ones added later.
- The environment-level checkbox turns read-only in the admin centre.
- Programmatic requests cannot override it either.
- Remove an environment from the group and it keeps the last value, but becomes editable again.

A checkbox is something a maker can flip back. A published group rule is not.

THE WORKAROUND

A trick that half-works

The idea I tested

Allocate the entire tenant pool to one dummy environment. Nothing is left unallocated, so nothing can be drawn.

TENANT PREPAID CREDIT POOL

Fully allocated to a dummy environment. Nothing left to draw.

Dev	Test	Production	Unowned
NOTHING TO DRAW	NOTHING TO DRAW	NOTHING TO DRAW	NOTHING TO DRAW

Why I am not recommending it

- It does nothing about pay-as-you-go — the bill that actually matters here.
- A tenant-wide lever for an environment-level problem.
- Microsoft documents the cross-drain: capacity allocated to environments reduces what is available to Cowork and Work IQ API.
- Credits reset monthly and never carry over. The parking needs upkeep.

Governing by starvation, when a checkbox and a group rule do the job properly.

THE ASYMMETRY

The control you get for Cowork, you do not get for agents

Microsoft 365 admin centre › Cost Management

Spending policies scoped by Entra security group, with tenant, group and per-user monthly credit limits, plus alerts and hard caps.

Cowork | Work IQ API

PER-USER LIMITS

Power Platform admin centre

Environment allocation, tenant draw, the group rule and a per-agent limit. No per-user control.

Copilot Studio agents

NO PER-USER LIMITS

Why the gap exists — and what it costs you

Agent consumption is attributed to an environment and an agent, never to a person. That is the same design decision that puts an autonomously triggered run outside the Microsoft 365 Copilot licence: there is no signed-in identity behind it. No identity to bill also means no identity to cap.

So for agents your blast radius is the environment, not the user. Design environments as budget boundaries, because that is the only boundary you get.

Per-user spending policies are currently available for Cowork and the Work IQ API only.

THE SHORT VERSION

What actually stops the spend

Environment allocation Sizes the budget. Not a boundary on its own.	Copilot Credits	PARTIAL
Draw from tenant capacity, off Closes prepaid draw for that environment.	Copilot Credits	STOPS PREPAID
Environment group rule Same control, applied as policy and locked.	Copilot Credits	STOPS PREPAID
Agent limit + Stop usage Turns the agent off at the limit.	Copilot Credits	TRUE HARD STOP
Per-user spending policy Caps one person's monthly credits. Cowork and Work IQ API only.	Real money on the Azure bill	NOT FOR AGENTS
Azure budgets and alerts Notifies finance. Does not stop consumption.	Real money on the Azure bill	ALERTS ONLY

Copilot Credits · Real money on the Azure bill · Cowork · Work IQ API

The meter is already running

Developer and trial environments moved to usage-based billing on 1 September. Filter the Harness column in your agent inventory to GitHub Copilot, find their environments, and close the tap on every one.

Vinod Dhanwe · Snr Solutions Architect · sources: Microsoft Learn, August 2026